

The three game design principles being defined are simplicity, pacing, and risk versus reward. A game that demonstrates simplicity well is *Stray*, a video game that is visually and acoustically appealing and easy for players of any skill level to pick up. Its straightforward controls and intuitive mechanics allow players to become immersed in the game's world and storytelling rather than focusing on mastering complex gameplay systems. Pacing is important for maintaining engagement and keeping the player entertained. A game that reflects this well is *Animal Crossing: New Horizons*, as its slow yet intentional pacing creates a relaxing experience. Its steady rhythm encourages players to take their time, appreciate small details, and find satisfaction in completing simple, everyday tasks. Risk versus reward is a principle that gives players the choice between taking a risk for potential rewards or playing it safe to avoid loss. An example of this is *Raft*, which challenges players to decide whether to explore the world, facing unknown dangers and risks, or stay safely on their raft. By taking risks, players can gain valuable materials and information that help them progress in the story and make survival tasks easier.

There are pros and cons to all of the principles I have discussed. For instance, simplicity makes a game more accessible to a wider audience, allowing for a larger player base, but it can also limit opportunities for exploration. In contrast, a more complex game allows for deeper exploration but can make it harder for beginners to learn and progress. Pacing at a natural and comfortable rate helps casual players learn and reduces the feeling of being overwhelmed. However, if not handled carefully, it can become repetitive or too slow, causing experienced players to lose interest or quit. Getting pacing right is challenging, as it requires extensive playtesting across various skill levels. Risk and reward is another difficult principle to balance. When done well, it gives players a sense of achievement, making success feel earned without making failure too punishing. However, if the balance is off, players may either avoid challenges altogether or become frustrated and give up. Depending on the game being built, game principles change according to the demographic and the intentions of the game.

The game I want to design is an auto-battler inspired by *Teamfight Tactics* and *Super Auto Pets*. Ideally, the basics of the game would be accessible to players of all skill levels, while later updates and patches could introduce more complexity. This approach ensures the game remains simple and approachable for beginners but allows for deeper mechanics and strategies to emerge as players progress. In games like the ones I'm inspired by, the pacing tends to be front-loaded, often overwhelming for newcomers, but that intensity is part of the charm. Although it can feel chaotic at first, it becomes deeply engaging, encouraging players to observe, adapt, and learn from their decisions and from the behavior of surrounding players. Risk and reward are also vital elements in auto-battlers, as every decision carries potential gains and losses. Players must decide when to level up, reroll for new units or items, and spend their currency strategically. A well-balanced system allows skilled players to take calculated risks while giving less experienced players room to develop their strategies over time. I'm designing an auto-battler inspired by *Teamfight Tactics* and *Super Auto Pets* that balances accessibility and depth, starting simple for beginners but evolving into a more strategic, risk-driven experience as players progress.

Sources Cited

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